ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Contrast and concession

Link opposing ideas with although, even though, despite, in spite of, whereas and while while controlling clause and noun forms. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use contrast and concession to acknowledge a counterpoint and show whether it changes the main conclusion while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Link opposing ideas with although, even though, despite, in spite of, whereas and while while controlling clause and noun forms.

MODEL

Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.

although + clause | despite + noun/-ing | whereas + contrasting clause

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main contrast and concession patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses acknowledge a counterpoint and show whether it changes the main conclusion.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in argument, discussion, reviews and formal comparison.

Build meaning before form

Link opposing ideas with although, even though, despite, in spite of, whereas and while while controlling clause and noun forms.

What contrast and concession communicates

Link opposing ideas with although, even though, despite, in spite of, whereas and while while controlling clause and noun forms.

The central purpose is to acknowledge a counterpoint and show whether it changes the main conclusion. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.	a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition
Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.	a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund
The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.	a direct comparison between two different facts

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: although + clause | despite + noun/-ing | whereas + contrasting clause. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Clause concession	although/even though + subject + verb	Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.
Nominal concession	despite/in spite of + noun/-ing	Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.
Balanced contrast	whereas/while + clause	The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition	Clause concession
a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund	Nominal concession
a direct comparison between two different facts	Balanced contrast

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in argument, discussion, reviews and formal comparison. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04	05	06
although	clause	despite	noun/-ing	whereas	contrasting clause

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: acknowledge a counterpoint and show whether it changes the main conclusion.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits argument, discussion, reviews and formal comparison.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Clause concession	although/even though + subject + verb	Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.
Nominal concession	despite/in spite of + noun/-ing	Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.
Balanced contrast	whereas/while + clause	The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.	a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition
Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.	a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund
The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.	a direct comparison between two different facts

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use but in the main clause after although.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not follow despite directly with a finite clause unless adding the fact that.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use whereas when the relationship is cause rather than contrast.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition?

OPTIONS Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term. · Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain. · The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund?

OPTIONS Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain. · The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality. · Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a direct comparison between two different facts?

OPTIONS The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality. · Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term. · Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition · a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund · a direct comparison between two different facts

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund · a direct comparison between two different facts · a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a direct comparison between two different facts · a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition · a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Clause concession / Nominal concession / Balanced contrast · Gap 2: a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition / a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund / a direct comparison between two different facts

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Nominal concession / Balanced contrast / Clause concession · Gap 2: a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund / a direct comparison between two different facts / a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Balanced contrast / Clause concession / Nominal concession · Gap 2: a direct comparison between two different facts / a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition / a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition: _____. Choose the model that expresses a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund: _____. Choose the model that expresses a direct comparison between two different facts: _____. Choose the model built with although/even though + subject + verb: _____. Choose the model built with despite/in spite of + noun/-ing: _____. Choose the model built with whereas/while + clause: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term. · Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain. · The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

_____, it may save money in the long term. _____ initially, the system is cheaper to maintain. The first option reduces cost, _____ the second improves quality. State the full structural pattern for Clause concession: _____. State the full structural pattern for Nominal concession: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The plan is expensive, but it may save money later.” using the Clause concession pattern to express a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The system costs more initially, yet maintenance is cheaper.” using the Nominal concession pattern to express a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Option one affects cost; option two affects quality.” using the Balanced contrast pattern to express a direct comparison between two different facts.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The plan is expensive, but it may save money later.” using the Clause concession pattern to express a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Clause concession to express a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Nominal concession to express a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Balanced contrast to express a direct comparison between two different facts, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.

Clause concession is the best match because a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition.

A2

Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.

Nominal concession is the best match because a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund.

A3

The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.

Balanced contrast is the best match because a direct comparison between two different facts.

A4

a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition

The Clause concession pattern communicates a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition.

A5

a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund

The Nominal concession pattern communicates a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund.

A6

a direct comparison between two different facts

The Balanced contrast pattern communicates a direct comparison between two different facts.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Clause concession / a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition

The structure belongs to the Clause concession pattern. Its communicative purpose is a surprising main result despite a full contrasting proposition.

B2

Nominal concession / a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund

The structure belongs to the Nominal concession pattern. Its communicative purpose is a concession packaged as a noun phrase or gerund.

B3

Balanced contrast / a direct comparison between two different facts

The structure belongs to the Balanced contrast pattern. Its communicative purpose is a direct comparison between two different facts.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.

Clause concession: although/even though + subject + verb.

C2

Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.

Nominal concession: despite/in spite of + noun/-ing.

C3

The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.

Balanced contrast: whereas/while + clause.

C4

Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.

Clause concession: although/even though + subject + verb.

C5

Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.

Nominal concession: despite/in spite of + noun/-ing.

C6

The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.

Balanced contrast: whereas/while + clause.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

Although the plan is expensive

Clause concession requires “Although the plan is expensive” in this model. although/even though + subject + verb.

D2

Despite costing more

Nominal concession requires “Despite costing more” in this model. despite/in spite of + noun/-ing.

D3

whereas

Balanced contrast requires “whereas” in this model. whereas/while + clause.

D4

although/even though + subject + verb

Clause concession is built as although/even though + subject + verb.

D5

despite/in spite of + noun/-ing

Nominal concession is built as despite/in spite of + noun/-ing.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.

although/even though + subject + verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended clause concession effect.

E2

Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain.

despite/in spite of + noun/-ing. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended nominal concession effect.

E3

The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality.

whereas/while + clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended balanced contrast effect.

E4

Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term.

although/even though + subject + verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended clause concession effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

Although the plan is expensive, it may save money in the long term. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses although/even though + subject + verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

Despite costing more initially, the system is cheaper to maintain. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses despite/in spite of + noun/-ing accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The first option reduces cost, whereas the second improves quality. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses whereas/while + clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____